

Nothing Ear (stick)

Good sound, lacking fit

Nothing, as a brand, has come to be synonymous with transparent tech. They started off with the Nothing Ear (1) in 2021. They have since launched a phone, the Nothing Phone (1) and now, another pair of earbuds, the Nothing Ear (stick). So, with the Nothing Ear (stick), their third launch since their start, were they able to live up to the expectations set by the Phone (1) and the Ear (1)? Let's find out.

BUILD AND DESIGN

One look at the Nothing Ear (stick) is enough to make you fall in love with the product. When new, the Nothing Ear (stick) looks, simply put, beautiful. The materials used are similar to what we saw with the Nothing Ear (1), it is plastic that looks almost like glass. However, this material gets scratched easily over time, which can spoil the look.

As Nothing says, the case's design is inspired by a lipstick case, meaning that you will have to rotate the bottom of the case, either clockwise or anticlockwise, to open it. The buds themselves follow a design language that is similar to that of the Ear (1). The major difference is the fit.

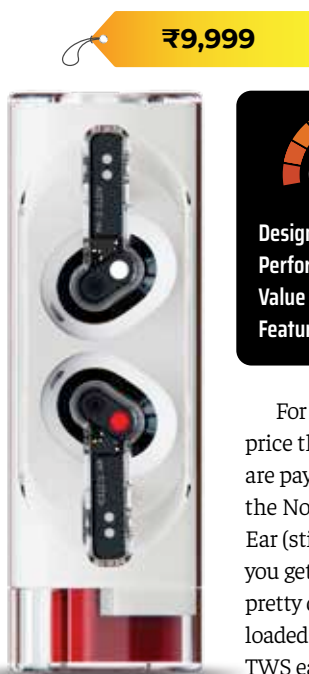
Given their half in ear design, they do not have the extended ear tip. This is where our issues with the Ear (stick) started. The half-in-ear design of the buds made it painful or difficult to wear for extended periods of time.

We passed them around to the team members to try on, and barely anyone found the buds to be a comfortable fit.

FEATURES

When talking about features, we didn't find anything outstanding about the Nothing Ear (stick). There is no Active Noise Cancellation and the passive isolation isn't great either.

As for the app, Nothing has introduced a new app called the Nothing X. It is where you will find all the customisation options that you need. It comes baked in with touch customisation options and a tri-band equaliser. However, the touch single press is not customisable at all.



nies like Sony and OPPO, which are in direct competition with Nothing in the market. Even the Ear (1) which launched last year and currently retails at a lower price, comes packing with a more diverse feature set.

PERFORMANCE

During our frequency response test, the results were not a hundred percent accurate as the design of the buds did not allow them to have a snug fit with the coupler of our test rig. But, from what we heard during our testing and observed from the graphs, we were not impressed.

The high mids are quite boosted and what happens in this case is that when listening to music and consuming other forms of content, the S and T sounds in the audio are amplified more than normal.

This not only adds an unnecessary harsh frequency that is being pumped out by the drivers, which otherwise fared well, but also it causes fatigue. As for other frequencies, which are the highs and the lows, they are adequate. Neither too harsh nor underemphasised. Circling back to the fit of the buds, if you do not get the tight seal around your ears, the bass might feel underemphasised.

If the fit is normal, then you are in for a treat. Given the half in ear design, the grill on the lobe of the buds sits right at the entrance of your ear canal. Which means you can feel the bass in the entire region around your ears.

In terms of connectivity, we did not encounter any problems. There were no lags or stutters in audio. The latency was minimal when consuming content or playing games. They also have Google Fast Pair and Microsoft Swift Pair enabled.

BATTERY

As per the claims made by Nothing, the buds when listening to music are supposed to last for up to seven hours. And, with the juice that is stored in the charging case, the battery life is supposed to go up to 29 hours of listening time. The Nothing Ear (stick) also supports fast charging which means a ten minute charge can fetch you about nine hours of listening time.

When these claims were put to test, to our surprise, almost all of them stood true. The buds in our music playback test, lasted for about six and a half hours at 60 per cent volume. The case provided an addition of five more rounds of charging with some juice left in it to spare.

VERDICT

All in all, the Nothing Ear (stick) makes for a decent pair of earbuds. The design and quality of the buds is great. And, if looked at in isolation, even the sound quality is decent for the price. However, given the half-in-ear design of the buds, there are a host of problems that might come your way. The buds are not feature-packed, but what is here is well executed and adds to making these a well-rounded package. The sound signature isn't something that will appease the audiophiles, but for day-to-day use, it is passable.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Bluetooth version: 5.2 | Battery life: 29 hr | Weight: 4.4g per earbud | Drivers: 12.6 mm custom driver | Battery life: Up to 29 hrs | IP Rating: IP54 | Sound Features - Sensitivity: 125 dBmW | Minimum Frequency Response: 20 Hz | Maximum Frequency Response: 20000 Hz | Wireless Range: 10 m

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